

DAY 4 · FOUNDATIONS · FULL-DAY WORKSHOP

The Web, HTML & CSS for the Newsroom

Read any page, structure it with HTML, style it with CSS — and put it to work on a story.



A hands-on coding day for journalists — half lecture, half building with a partner

HOW TODAY WORKS

The Web, HTML & CSS for the Newsroom



Morning · Foundations

What is code, how the web actually works, and how to read any page.

LECTURE



Midday · HTML by hand

Structure a page with tags — then build your first one with a partner.

HANDS-ON



Afternoon · CSS by hand

Make it look like a newsroom — then style your page with a partner.

HANDS-ON



Late day · Make it count

Three ways this pays off on a story, then a mini-build you present.

HANDS-ON

WHY A REPORTER LEARNS THIS

What HTML & CSS unlock on the desk



Present data yourself

Create a spreadsheet or scrape data into a page that readers can actually use.



Give a story a home

Build a clean, custom page for the investigation that can be easily shared and presented.



Read the web like a source

See any site's structure — useful for scraping, verifying, and reporting.



Speak the devs' language

Brief the web team precisely; know what's a five-minute ask vs. a project.

You don't need to become a developer. You need to have the knowledge to build the small things yourself.

THE HOUSE RULES

How we'll learn — together



Work in pairs

Turn to the person beside you now — that's your partner all day. One screen, two brains.



Predict, then run

Before you hit refresh, say out loud what you think will happen. Trial and error is the best way to learn.



Break things on purpose

Delete a tag. Change a number. Watch it fall over, then put it back. That's not damage — that's understanding.



Ask your partner first

Stuck? Explain it to your neighbor before you raise a hand. Teaching is how it sticks.

PART 1

What is code?

Before we write any, let's agree on what it even is.



THE WHOLE IDEA IN ONE LINE

Code is just a way to talk to computers



You already speak languages. Code is one more — a very literal one, spoken to a machine.



It's a set of instructions You tell the computer exactly what to do, step by step.



It's written, not spoken You type it in a file; the computer reads it top to bottom.



Different jobs, different languages Like human languages, each one is good at certain things.

THE ONE HABIT THAT SAVES YOU

Computers follow instructions — not your intentions



WHAT YOU MEANT

“Color me in with some nice, tasteful colors.”



WHAT THE COMPUTER HEARD

“Okay!” → neon purple polka dots.



“Computers are good at following instructions, but not at reading your mind.” — Donald Knuth

THE WEB RUNS ON THREE

The three languages of the web



HTML

STRUCTURE

The bones. Headlines, paragraphs, images, links — what's on the page.



CSS

STYLE

The paint. Colors, fonts, spacing, layout — how the page looks.



JavaScript

BEHAVIOR

The motion. Clicks, search, interactivity — what the page does.

Today is all about the first two — HTML and CSS. They're enough to build and style a real page.



The Inspect Element safari



Your task: *Every site you visit is just HTML you're allowed to read. Let's go read some.*

STEPS

- 1 Open Chrome and go to your own newsroom's homepage.
- 2 Right-click the main headline → choose “Inspect.”
- 3 Find the highlighted tag wrapping the headline text.
- 4 Tell your partner: what tag is it? (h1? h2? a?)
- 5 Double-click the headline text in the panel and retype it.
- 6 Watch your own “headline” appear on the live page.



Stretch goal: Find the tag wrapping a photo. What's the attribute that points to the image file?

PART 2

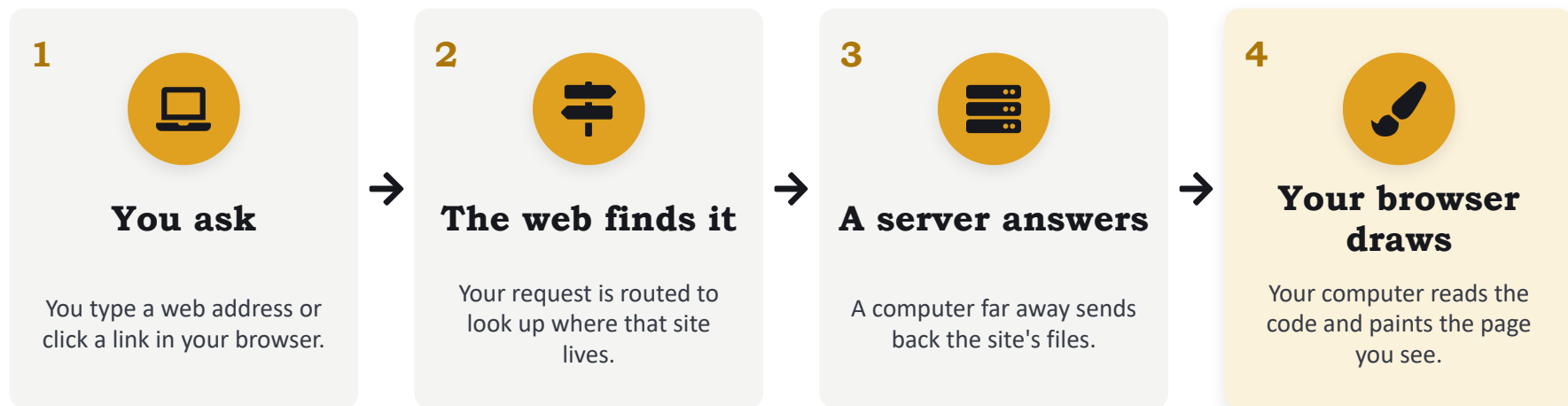
How websites work

What actually happens between clicking a link and seeing a page.



CLICK A LINK — THEN WHAT?

The journey of a page request



The whole trip takes **a fraction of a second** — and it happens every single time a page loads.

THE REFRAME THAT UNLOCKS EVERYTHING

A website is just files a browser draws

HTML, CSS, and JavaScript are **instructions for your computer to draw a website.**



The server just hands over the code It doesn't send a finished picture — it sends the instructions, and your browser does the drawing.



That's why you can always read it The code arrives on your machine, so any page's structure is yours to inspect (like the safari).



And why what you build is portable Your page is a plain file. Put it anywhere a browser can reach it and it works.

PART 3

HTML — the structure

The bones of every page: tags that say what each thing is.



WHAT HTML DOES

HTML says what each thing is

It doesn't make things pretty. It labels the parts of your page so the browser knows a headline is a headline, a paragraph is a paragraph, and an image is an image.

Think of it as the skeleton — plain, unstyled, but holding everything up.

YOUR HTML

```
<h1>Records reveal  
    permit backlog</h1>  
  
<p>A six-month review  
    found ...</p>  
  

```

THE BUILDING BLOCK

Tags: an opening, a closing, and content between

```
<h1> Records reveal permit backlog </h1>
```

opening tag

content

closing tag

-  **The tag name says what it is** h1 is a big headline. Swap it for h2, p, or li and the meaning changes.
-  **The slash marks the end** </h1> closes what <h1> opened. Forget it and the page misbehaves below.
-  **This is your first thing to break** In the workshop, delete a closing tag on purpose and watch what happens.

YOUR STARTER VOCABULARY

The handful of tags you'll mostly use



`<h1>` ... `<h2>`

Headlines & subheads



`<p>`

A paragraph of text



`<a>`

A link to another page



`<img>`

An image



`<strong>`

Bold / important text



`<ul>` `<li>`

A bulleted list

Six tags. That's genuinely enough to build a real story page — you'll use all of them in the next workshop.

Attributes: the details a tag needs

```

```

attribute (which detail)

value (what it's set to)



src Where the image lives — a filename or a web link.



href Where a link goes — used on the <a> tag.



Some tags stand alone has no closing tag — it's self-contained. Not every tag comes in a pair.

TWO MINUTES OF SETUP

Set up your workspace



1. Make a folder

On your desktop, create a folder called Code, and inside it another called newsroom.



2. Open your editor

Open the text editor we installed (VS Code / Sublime). This is where you'll write.



3. Create the file

In the newsroom folder, make a new file named practice.html.



4. Open it two ways

Keep it open in the editor to write and open the file in Chrome to see it.

The trick all day: editor on the left to write, Chrome on the right to see. Save, then refresh.



Build your first page



Your task: *Turn an empty file into a real, structured news page — using only the six tags.*

STEPS

- 1 In practice.html, add an `<h1>` headline for a made-up story.
- 2 Add two `<p>` paragraphs of body text below it.
- 3 Add an `<img>` with a `src` (any image link works).
- 4 Add an `<a>` link to a real source or document.
- 5 Save, refresh Chrome, and read your page together.
- 6 Break it: delete one `</p>` — refresh — then put it back.



Stretch goal: Add a `<ul>` list of three bullet points, and make one word `<strong>`.

PART 4

CSS — the style

Same HTML, restyled: colors, fonts, spacing, and layout.



WHAT CSS DOES

CSS is how the page looks

HTML ALONE

Records reveal permit backlog

A six-month review of city files found hundreds of permits stalled past the legal deadline.

WITH CSS

Records reveal permit backlog

A six-month review of city files found hundreds of permits stalled past the legal deadline.

Exact same words and tags. CSS only changed the colors, fonts, spacing, and alignment.

THE CLICK THAT MAKES CSS MAKE SENSE

CSS points at your HTML tags by name

A CSS rule starts by naming the tag it wants to style — **the same tag names from your HTML, just without the angle brackets.**

HTML

`<body>`



CSS SELECTOR

`body`

HTML

`<h1>`



CSS SELECTOR

`h1`

HTML

`<p>`



CSS SELECTOR

`p`

HTML

`<img>`



CSS SELECTOR

`img`

So “style every paragraph” is just: `p { ... }`. If you know your HTML tags, you already know your CSS selectors.

Selector, property, value

```
p {  
  text-align: center;  
  color: white;  
}
```



selector

which tag to style (p)



property

what to change (color)



value

what to set it to (white)

YOUR STARTER PALETTE

The properties you'll reach for first



color

Text color



background-color

Background fill



font-size

How big the text is



text-align

Left, center, right



margin
padding

Space around & inside



border

A line around a box

Colors can be names (white, navy) or hex codes (#16181D). You'll use both in the next workshop.

Connect your CSS to your page



1. Make style.css

In the same newsroom folder, create a file called style.css.



2. Link it in your HTML

Add one line inside your page so it knows to load the styles.



3. Write a rule

Add `body { background-color: #2B2E37; }` and save both files.



4. Refresh & see it

Reload Chrome — your background changes. You're styling now.

The link line: `<link rel="stylesheet" href="style.css">`



Style your page



Your task: *Take the plain page you built this morning and make it look like a newsroom made it.*

STEPS

- 1 Create style.css and link it in practice.html.
- 2 Style body: a background-color and a readable font.
- 3 Style h1: a color, and text-align: center.
- 4 Style p: color and comfortable font-size.
- 5 Give your img a border and some margin.
- 6 Predict each change before you refresh to confirm.

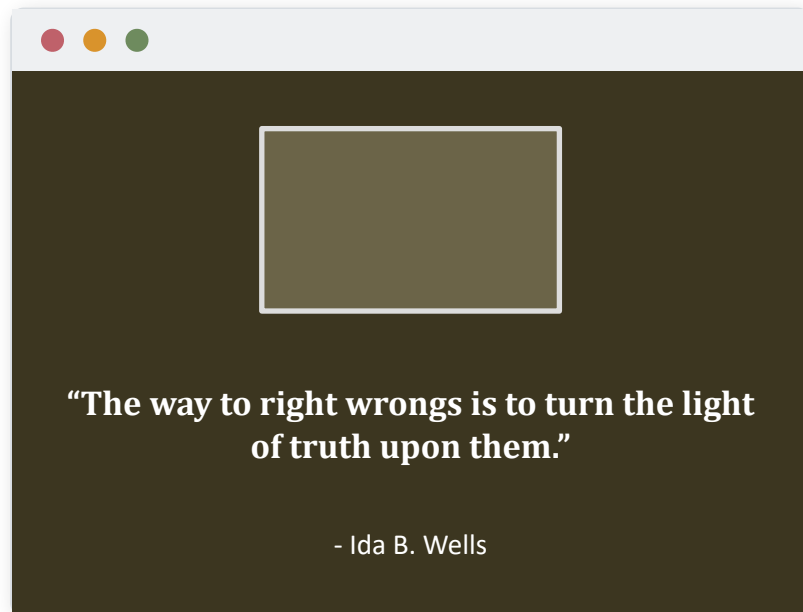
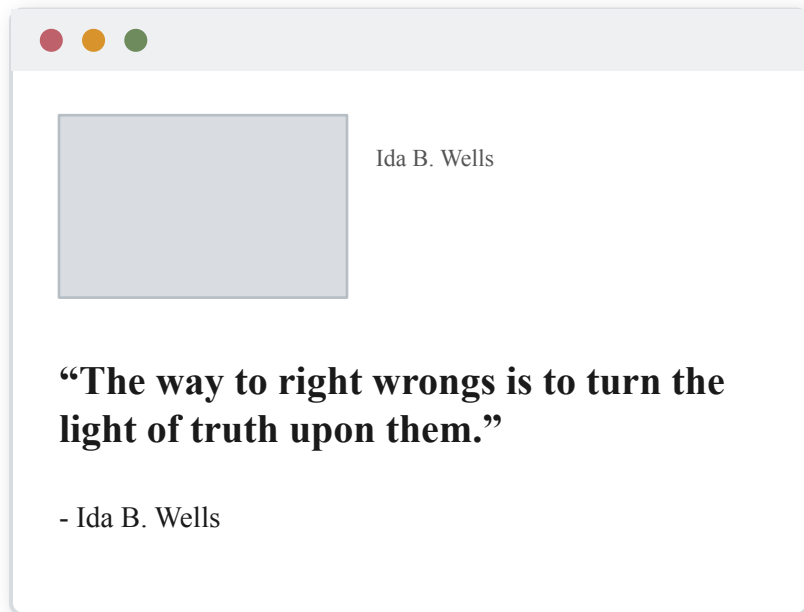


Stretch goal: Rebuild the classic quote card: a photo with a border, a big centered headline, and an attribution line beneath — like the Ida B. Wells example.

Same HTML. Two completely different pages.

BEFORE · NO CSS

AFTER · OPTIMIZED CSS



Default browser styles. Left-aligned. No hierarchy, no color, no breathing

One file, style.css: centered, framed, color, shadow, hierarchy.

Not one word of HTML changed. Every visual difference above came from a single stylesheet — that's the leverage of optimizing your CSS.

PART 5

Make it count for the newsroom

Three small builds that punch above their weight on a story.



SMALL PAGES, REAL IMPACT

Three ways reporters put this to work



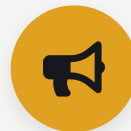
The story card

A single styled page for a quote, a finding, or a key document — clean enough to share on social and stand on its own.



The simple data callout

Take a short list — closures, violations, donations — and lay it out as a clear, readable page instead of burying it in prose.



The “reach me” page

A tidy page that says who you are, what you're investigating, and how a source can safely get in touch.

All three are just HTML + CSS — exactly what you learned today. Pick one to build in the final workshop.



With your neighbor

Newsroom mini-build



55 min

Your task: *Pick one of the three pages and build a real, styled version with your partner — then show it off.*

STEPS

- 1 Choose: story card, data callout, or “reach me” page.
- 2 Start a fresh file; sketch the structure in HTML first.
- 3 Style it with CSS until it looks intentional.
- 4 Use a real (public) detail from your own beat if you can.
- 5 Pair up with another team and discuss.
- 6 Give each other one thing that works, one to improve.



Stretch goal: Add a second styled section (a sub-headline, a list, or a caption) so the page has real structure, not just one block.

LOOK HOW FAR YOU CAME

What you can do now



Read the web Open any page and see the HTML underneath.



Structure with HTML Lay out a page with headlines, text, images, links.



Style with CSS Control color, type, spacing, and layout.



TOMORROW · DAY 5

Build faster with Claude

- Direct Claude to summarize pages for you.
- Read every line — today made you able to.
- Publish to a real, live URL.

Everything tomorrow rests on today. You can only direct — and trust — code you're able to read.



You can read and build for the web.

Structure it with HTML. Style it with CSS. Ship the file.

Questions now — and bring your practice page tomorrow for Day 5.